Let the *Music Play*

MUSIC

From commercial hip-hop to old-school conscious rap, from **peppy, pop-leaning indie-rock to earthy avant-folk** experiments, these new releases have something for everyone



EK THA RAJA
Badshah

Rapper and pop star Badshah follows up last year's collab-heavy EP *3:00 AM Sessions* with yet another star-studded lineup of guest stars on his new album *Ek Tha Raja*. He teams up with former *Mafia Mundeer* crewmate Raftaar and frequent collaborator Aastha Gill on the club-friendly 'Like a Snake', trades bars with indie rappers Seedhe Maut ('Bajenge') and Raga ('Alag Hai'), and even drafts Arijit Singh and Nora Fatehi for vocal duties.



D.O.N.L.Y.F
Shaikhspeare

One of the OGs of Mumbai underground rap, Shaikhspeare returns to the limelight with *D.O.N.L.Y.F*, a boombap-infused conscious rap album that takes a stark look at India's contemporary ills. The rabble-rousing 'Bol'—which features a guest verse by Kolkata rapper EPR Iyer—borrows its hook from a Faiz Ahmed Faiz poem and takes aim at the communalisation of contemporary politics. 'Ashfaqullah Khan' is a braggadocio cut where Shaikhspeare recasts himself in the mould of the Indian independence icon. Elsewhere, the inward-looking 'Aamir' chronicles the rapper's journey to music as a child from a conservative Muslim family.

MUSEUM, *Tejas*

Mumbai indie singer-songwriter Tejas Menon fuses Indian classical music with his trademark blend of pop, soul and synth-wave electronics on his new EP *Museum*. The sarangi and Hindustani classical vocals rub shoulders with shimmering synths and gospel choirs on song-length ruminations on identity and personal history, inspired by the recent passing of his father. It's four tracks of grandly ambitious and intimately cathartic music.





AN ODE TO LOVE

IP Singh and Rajarshi Sanyal-the duo behind **Faridkot**–tell us about their new collection of tracks, *Ibtida*

One of India's most popular pop-rock bands, Faridkot—composed of the duo IP Singh and Rajarshi Sanyal—is back after a hiatus with *Ibtida*, an EP with five tracks. This EP with music giant T-Series, says Sanyal, has everything to do with love. "It's the first time we've made an entire album on love that manifests in different forms. It's not just romantic love but love for our art, nature or humanity."

Ibtida includes tracks like 'Ek Samay' and 'Main Na Jaanu Kyu' with singer Jubin Nautiyal and 'Chhad

